

The AO Culture 5

Practical Guide: inspiring language, orthodontic examples, reflection questions, and behaviors for daily use.

1

OWN IT

Take responsibility.
Be reliable.
Follow through.

2

FIND A WAY

Take initiative.
Solve problems.
Be resourceful.

3

ONE TEAM

Communicate.
Support each other.
Respect each other.

4

BETTER EVERY DAY

Learn. Improve.
Train. Build
better systems.

5

PATIENT FIRST

Quality care.
Clear communication.
Exceptional experience.

“At Alexandria Orthodontics, we own our responsibilities, find solutions, support our team, improve every day, and put our patients first.”

How to use this guide

Use the five pillars as a common language for coaching, huddles, reflection, and day-to-day decisions. The goal is not perfection. The goal is a team that can recognize problems, take responsibility, communicate, improve systems, and protect the patient experience.

Universal non-negotiables: Respect. Integrity. Safety. Always.

1

OWN IT

Take responsibility. Be reliable. Follow through.

“A system only works if we keep doing it after the meeting is over.”

What this means at AO

OWN IT is not about never making mistakes. It is about recognizing what belongs to us and following it through to completion. A common failure point is not creating a bad system - it is allowing a good system to disappear after two weeks.

Orthodontic examples

- **End-of-day reports:** A process is created, followed for a short time, then slowly abandoned. Ownership means the process has a clear owner and continues without repeated reminders.
- **Checking scans for the lab:** Before leaving, confirm that needed scans were reviewed and the lab has what it needs. Avoid 'I thought someone else checked them.'
- **Missing documentation:** If a Next Visit note is blank or inaccurate, recognize it, correct it, and finish the responsibility rather than hoping someone else catches it.

Reflection questions

- What is my responsibility here?
- Did I complete it?
- If our system stopped working, did I notice and say something?
- Am I waiting for someone else to catch the problem?

Simple AO reminder

See it. Own it. Finish it.

2

FIND A WAY

Take initiative. Solve problems. Be resourceful.

“A workaround gets us through the moment. A solution keeps the problem from coming back.”

What this means at AO

Find a Way means we do not stop at identifying the problem. We use the correct resources, create a safe short-term plan when needed, and start the real solution before the problem becomes larger.

Orthodontic examples

- **Broken computer at a chair:** Using another chair may get us through the next patient, but leaving the computer broken removes capacity when the clinic gets busy. Report the problem, fill out the equipment form, identify the specialist who owns the repair, and start the fix early.
- **IDB tray problem:** If an upper tray did not print correctly, do not simply stop the case. Communicate the issue, prepare what can be prepared, use the trays that are ready, reprint what is needed, and provide a realistic ETA.
- **Important distinction:** Resourcefulness does not mean guessing or working outside your role. Patient safety and issues outside your authority should be escalated appropriately.

A useful mindset

Temporary workaround: 'Use another chair.'

Find a Way: 'Use another chair for now. I documented the problem, contacted the right person, and the repair is already moving.'

Simple AO reminder

Solve today's problem without creating tomorrow's problem.

3

ONE TEAM

Communicate. Support each other. Respect each other.

“The patient sees one office. They should experience one team.”

What this means at AO

One of our biggest opportunities is reducing the separation between Front Desk / Treatment Coordination and the Clinical Team. Doctors should not have to be the constant bridge carrying information from one side of the office to the other.

Orthodontic examples

- **Scan support:** Yeymy needs a scan for a consultation patient. Jocelyn asks over the radio, 'Randy or Nataly, are you able to do a scan on a patient?' A tech replies, 'Yes. Which chair?' That is one team.
- **Busy clinic:** The question is not only 'Is my column caught up?' The better question is 'Are we caught up?'
- **Cross-team communication:** If a patient strongly prefers appointments after 3:30, communicate that preference to the front desk so the patient does not have to repeat the conversation.
- **Reduce silos:** Information should move directly between teams whenever possible instead of relying on the doctor as the messenger.

Questions to ask

- Who needs this information besides me?
- Is another department struggling while I have capacity to help?
- Am I protecting only my workflow, or the workflow of the office?
- Does the doctor really need to be the messenger here?

Simple AO reminder

Different roles. Same patient. Same team.

4

BETTER EVERY DAY

Learn. Improve. Train. Build better systems.

“Being on time is not the same as being ready.”

What this means at AO

One of our major opportunities is preparation. We can arrive 'on time' and still be unprepared. Better Every Day means studying the systems, reviewing the schedule, planning the day, learning from what went wrong, and then staying consistent with the improvement.

Preparation before clinic

- Where is doctor time concentrated?
- Are there potential bottlenecks, bondings, emergencies, or unusual appointments?
- Is somebody absent, and does someone need to float?
- Are trays, brackets, suction, handpieces, and materials ready?
- Are there problems later in the day that we can solve now?

Orthodontic example: recurring emergency 7 tubes

Instead of accepting 'we are getting a lot of emergencies,' investigate the process: Are we sand conditioning? Yes. Are we isolating sufficiently? Yes. Are we using the PFI to butter adhesive into the bracket pad? No. That becomes an actionable system improvement: **PFI at every bonding**, followed by monitoring whether the emergency rate improves.

After a difficult session

- What created the delay?
- Where did the problem actually start?
- Could we have seen it coming?
- What do we change tomorrow?
- How do we make sure the change lasts longer than two weeks?

Simple AO reminder

Prepare. Reflect. Improve. Repeat.

5

PATIENT FIRST

Quality care. Clear communication. Exceptional experience.

“The patient should never feel the gaps between our systems.”

What this means at AO

Patient First is more than friendliness. It includes safety, time, communication, comfort, guidance, and quality. The patient should feel cared for even when the office is busy.

Orthodontic examples

- **Safety glasses:** Patient safety should be automatic. A seated patient should have safety glasses before treatment begins.
- **Mindfulness about time:** A patient seated for ten minutes without communication may wonder whether they were forgotten. Someone should notice, acknowledge the delay, and communicate what is happening.
- **Warm handoff:** Yeymy closes the loop with the patient's dentist, lets the patient know they are cleared to start, listens to the financial concern, then personally walks the patient to Yadira instead of pointing across the office.
- **Cross-training:** The more each department understands the other, the fewer times patients hear 'I don't know' or 'you'll have to ask someone else.'
- **Scheduling communication:** If the patient tells the clinical team they strongly prefer a certain appointment time, communicate that preference so they do not need to repeat it at checkout.

The Patient First question

What creates the best combination of quality, safety, communication, and experience for the patient?

Simple AO reminder

Don't point. Don't pass off. Guide the patient all the way.

How the five pillars work together

These are not five separate ideas. They form a sequence for how AO responds to problems and opportunities.

OWN IT	I recognize and accept my responsibility.
FIND A WAY	I move toward a safe, practical solution.
ONE TEAM	I communicate and involve the people who can help.
BETTER EVERY DAY	We learn from what happened and improve the system.
PATIENT FIRST	The patient benefits from everything above.

“We own our responsibilities, find solutions, support our team, improve every day, and ultimately create a better experience for the patient.”

Respect. Integrity. Safety. Always.

The standard is not perfection. The standard is ownership, communication, learning, teamwork, and exceptional patient care.